NSF I-Corps
Customer Interview Form

NSF I-Corps Team:	**Team #003, Fruitful Network Development**				
Entrepreneurial Lead:	Dylan Montgomery	Mentor:		Faculty Lead:	

Customer Interviews

Market Segment:	**Agricultural Network: Buyer**

Customer Name:	*Email:*	*Phone:*	*Date Contacted:*
Emily Able			04 /15 /2025
Company Name:	University of Charleston SC	*Job Title:*	Student

What 1 or 2 hypotheses are you trying to test in this interview? (Hypotheses are statements, not questions; they often start with "I think…")	**Market Validation (Speaking to industry individuals):** - **Do buyers feel disconnected from local producers?** - **Do Buyers notice an underrepresentation online?** - **If buyers want better access to local, ethical food but don't know where to start?** - **If small producers are limited more by infrastructure and visibility than demand.** - **Whether consumer and vendor agency is a missing ingredient in current market systems.**

Use the space provided to list prepared questions, with space below each for notes, for your interview.	**Goals:**
	- **To understand the potential customer's top 2-3 problems**
	- **To understand the potential customer's current processes**
	- **To understand further downstream implications of the problem**
	- **To understand try to quantify the severity of the problem**
	- **To understand the limitations of the customer's current solutions**
	- **To understand the decision-making process**
	- **To understand what the current budget is for solving the problem**
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	Question:
	- **What technological uses and costs (Website, Software, Service portals, Phones, Internet, Email, Hardware, POS, ect.)**
	- **What considerations are there in expanding operations?**
	- **What problems have you faced with short shelf life and fragile products?**
	- **How are internal operations challenged for a family farm (Software/hardware)?**
	  - **And externally for family farms or other Network individuals?**
	- **Most costly part of being a vendor**
	- **How do you stay engaged**
	- **How have you found out about Markets and HUBs**
	- **What info do you wish you knew about suppliers**
	- **What do you wish people new**
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	Notes:
	- **Emily mentioned that she's noticed the price being more expensive at farmers markets, than at the grocery store.**
	- **The selection at the farmers markets also seem to be largely limited to fruits, vegetables, baked goods, and Honey.**
	  - **This limits her ability to visit the farmers markets as a one stop shop location**
	- **She also mentioned that many of the times that she does visit the farmers markets she must have people she knows drive her, as she doesn't have a car.**
	  - **She said, "I don't know how, but every community really should have a way for people to have the option to go to a farmers markets. The same way we maintain rods and stuff"**
	- **As of lately she also mentioned that she's noticed that grocery prices are definitely on the rise, and she might as well go to the farmers markets whenever she can this summer. If she's going to be paying the same amount of money, she'd rather not eat pesticides instead.**
	- **She only visits the one, however this was by word of mouth and it doesn't seem that there are very many near here in general.**
	- **As far as things that she wished she new ahead of time, she said that it would have been nice to know some of the prices she could get different products at for different stands**
	- **She told one vendor that she could get a a lb of spinach for 5 dollars at another stand rather than for 8, and the vendor justified saying "Thats because they use a ton of fertilizers and have a lot more output, but no nutrients"**

What were the key things you learned from this conversation? Summarize your takeaways here.	**Notes:**
	- **I notice that many people really don't realize what organic means, or it has been commercialized so much that it means something different to everyone. Even those that know about the certification, don't really have the connection to the farms to understand that it might not be certified, but that it is mainly due to it being geared toward industrial farms.**
	- **I also wasn't expecting Charleston SC to have the same issue of only having farmers markets in the summer, I guess that further a the point that grocery stores won't be going anywhere anytime store, but I wonder if there is room for a company to have a chain of indoor markets, like a mall.**
	  - **On that note, I wonder if all of these abandoned malls have an opportunity in them to transform into indoor markets.**
	- **I wonder if farmers markets have a priority in confirming practices and quality**
	  - **If not, I wonder if there is a push for faremr's markets to join, in effect, 'standardization unions' whose main purpose is to insure standardized practices across markets and organizer of location. Maybe that'd be a vendor to vendor choice. All of these could be easily developed as grouping curations on the framework websites are made on.**
	
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	More notes on next page: